NEVADA

The Silver State



Nevada was born from the earth up—silver veins running through the Virginia Range, cattle grazing the high desert valleys, and men willing to stake everything on what lay beneath the surface or beyond the next ridge. It was a land of appetite in every sense, and nothing satisfied that appetite quite like a prime rib roast carved thick and set in the center of a table full of hungry people.

When the Comstock Lode exploded in 1859, Virginia City became one of the wealthiest and most chaotic cities in the American West almost overnight. Miners, speculators, railroad workers, and entrepreneurs flooded into the Nevada Territory, and with them came the demand for food that matched the scale of their ambitions. The cattle industry had already taken root in the region's wide open valleys—ranchers like Henry Blasdel, Nevada's first state governor, understood early that the land which couldn't be farmed could still be grazed. Enormous herds moved through the valleys of Elko and Lovelock counties, supplying beef to the mining camps and the railroad crews pushing the transcontinental line westward toward Promontory Summit.

The grand hotels and saloons of Virginia City set the early standard. Places like the International Hotel—at the time one of the tallest buildings west of the Mississippi—served elaborate dining room suppers to men who had struck it rich and wanted the world to know it. Prime rib, slow-roasted and served in generous cuts with horseradish and pan jus, became the centerpiece of that ambition. It was a dish that communicated prosperity without pretension, the kind of meal that said a man had made something of himself without requiring him to use the right fork.

That tradition deepened when Las Vegas transformed itself in the mid-20th century. The grand casino resorts that rose from the Mojave Desert—the El Rancho, the Flamingo, the Golden Nugget—competed fiercely for the loyalty of gamblers and showgoers, and the surest way to keep a guest at the table was to feed them extraordinarily well at an extraordinarily low price. Prime rib became the signature offering of the Las Vegas casino dining room, slow-roasted in house, carved tableside by a skilled hand, and served at prices that defied reason. It was both a pleasure and a strategy—and Nevadans embraced it entirely.

What has endured across the mining camps, the cattle ranches, and the glittering casino floors is the same essential truth: a well-made prime rib roast is one of the most deeply satisfying things a cook can put on a table. The crust seasoned dark and fragrant, the interior blushing pink from edge to edge, the juices pooling beneath the carving knife—it rewards patience and repays the effort many times over. This is the dish Nevada claimed as its own, and once you pull it from the oven and feel the warmth rising from the roast, you'll understand exactly why.

BUFFET-STYLE PRIME RIB ROAST WITH PAN JUS

A prime rib roast commands the room—herb-crusted, rose-blushed, and met with a reverent hush the moment it hits the table.

Yield: 8–12 servings

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INGREDIENTS

- 1 (6 to 8 lb.) boneless prime rib roast (or bone-in if preferred)
- 2–3 Tbsp salt
- 1 Tbsp freshly ground black pepper
- 2 Tbsp garlic powder
- 2 Tbsp onion powder
- 1 Tbsp dried rosemary (or thyme)
- 1 Tbsp smoked paprika (optional, for extra depth)
- 2 Tbsp olive oil or softened butter

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Prepare the roast (1–2 days before cooking)*: Pat the roast dry with paper towels. Mix salt, pepper, garlic powder, onion powder, rosemary, and the optional smoked paprika. Rub olive oil or butter over the roast, then coat generously with the seasoning mix. Place the roast on a rack in a roasting pan or sheet tray and refrigerate uncovered for 12–48 hours—this dry brine enhances flavor and creates a great crust.
2. *Cook the roast (day of)*: Remove the roast from the fridge 1 hour before cooking to come to room temperature. Preheat the oven to 200°F (93°C). Place the roast on a rack in a shallow roasting pan, fat side up, and roast for 3½–4½ hours until it reaches your desired doneness: 120°F (49°C) for rare, 130°F (54°C) for medium-rare, or 140°F (60°C) for medium (a common buffet target). Remove from the oven, tent loosely with foil, and let rest for 30 minutes.
3. *Final sear (optional but recommended)*: Increase the oven to 500°F (260°C), or heat a grill or cast iron pan. Sear the exterior for 6–10 minutes until dark brown and crisp.
4. *For buffet holding*: Slice the prime rib and transfer to a warmed chafing dish. Keep the slices in warm pan jus, held at 140–150°F (60–65°C), for up to 1½–2 hours without drying out.

PAN JUS

Yield: about 2 cups

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INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups beef broth, plus any drippings from the roasting pan
- Splash of red wine (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Make the pan jus*: In the roasting pan, add the beef broth and red wine, if using, and simmer while scraping up the browned bits from the bottom of the pan.
2. *Strain*: Strain the drippings and serve warm alongside the sliced meat.

